

CBT WORKBOOK FOR DEPRESSION

Break the Cycle of Negative Thinking

Behavioral Activation, Mood Tracking &
Evidence-Based Exercises for Recovery

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Practical Tools for Managing Depression

CBT Workbook for Depression

Break the Cycle of Negative Thinking

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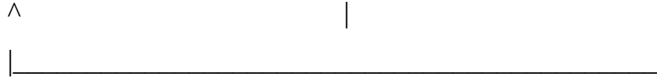
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UNDERSTANDING THE DEPRESSION CYCLE

Depression creates a vicious cycle that keeps you stuck:

LOW MOOD --> WITHDRAWAL --> LESS ACTIVITY --> FEWER REWARDS



When you feel depressed, you naturally do less. But doing less means fewer opportunities for pleasure, accomplishment, and connection.

This CONFIRMS depressive thoughts ('Nothing matters', 'I can't do anything').

CBT for depression breaks this cycle through BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION:

Instead of waiting to feel motivated, you ACT FIRST and let mood follow.

KEY PRINCIPLE: Action comes BEFORE motivation, not after.

The Depression Triangle:

THOUGHTS: 'I'm worthless, nothing will help, what's the point'

FEELINGS: Sad, empty, hopeless, guilty, irritable

BEHAVIORS: Isolating, sleeping too much, avoiding tasks

This workbook will help you:

1. Identify YOUR depression cycle
2. Schedule activities that bring pleasure and mastery
3. Challenge hopelessness and self-critical thoughts
4. Build energy gradually through structured activation
5. Prevent relapse by recognizing warning signs early

BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION: ACTIVITY SCHEDULING

Schedule activities BEFORE you feel like doing them.

Rate each: P = Pleasure (0-10) M = Mastery (0-10)

Time	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
7 AM							
9 AM							
11 AM							
1 PM							
3 PM							
5 PM							
7 PM							
9 PM							

End-of-week reflection: Which activities improved my mood most?

PLEASURE & MASTERY ACTIVITY LIST

Rate activities you USED to enjoy or that give a sense of accomplishment.

P = Pleasure (how enjoyable) M = Mastery (sense of achievement) Both 0-10

Activity	P Rating	M Rating	Schedule?
Walking outside			
Calling a friend			
Cooking a meal			
Reading a book			
Listening to music			
Taking a shower/bath			
Light exercise			
Gardening			
Watching a favorite show			
Completing a small task			
Helping someone			
Creative activity			
Going to a cafe			
Playing with a pet			
Organizing one drawer			

My own activities:

CHALLENGING HOPELESSNESS THOUGHTS

Depression tells you lies disguised as facts. Common hopeless thoughts:

'Nothing will ever get better'

'I'm a burden to everyone'

'What's the point of trying'

'I'll always feel this way'

'I don't deserve to be happy'

CHALLENGING THESE THOUGHTS:

1. What is the thought? _____

2. What evidence SUPPORTS this thought?

3. What evidence CONTRADICTS this thought?

4. Am I confusing a FEELING with a FACT? Yes / No

5. What would I say to a friend thinking this?

6. A more balanced thought:

7. Belief in hopeless thought now (0-100%): _____

GRATITUDE REFRAMING EXERCISE

Depression narrows your focus to the negative. Gratitude retrains attention.

This is NOT toxic positivity - it's noticing what depression makes invisible.

Day 1:

Three small things I noticed today (not big - tiny is fine):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Day 2:

Three small things I noticed today (not big - tiny is fine):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Day 3:

Three small things I noticed today (not big - tiny is fine):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Day 4:

Three small things I noticed today (not big - tiny is fine):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Day 5:

Three small things I noticed today (not big - tiny is fine):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Day 6:

Three small things I noticed today (not big - tiny is fine):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Day 7:

Three small things I noticed today (not big - tiny is fine):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

ENERGY MANAGEMENT FOR DEPRESSION

Depression drains energy. You cannot do everything. Prioritize wisely.

THE SPOON THEORY FOR DEPRESSION:

Imagine you start each day with 10 spoons of energy.

Each task costs spoons. When they're gone, you're done.

Rate your energy today (1-10): _____

MUST DO (costs 1-2 spoons each):

SHOULD DO (costs 2-3 spoons each):

WOULD LIKE TO DO (costs 1 spoon - only if energy remains):

ENERGY BOOSTERS (give spoons back):

SOCIAL WITHDRAWAL PREVENTION PLAN

Depression makes you want to isolate. Isolation makes depression worse.
You don't need to be social - just CONNECTED.

MY MINIMUM SOCIAL CONTACTS (aim for at least 1 per day):

LOW ENERGY OPTIONS (when everything feels too hard):

- Send one text message to someone
- Reply to one message I've been avoiding
- Sit in a public place (cafe, park) for 10 min
- Say hi to one neighbor or coworker

MEDIUM ENERGY OPTIONS:

- Call someone for 5-10 minutes
- Accept one invitation this week
- Eat one meal with another person
- Attend one regular activity (class, meeting)

HIGH ENERGY OPTIONS (for better days):

- Plan a small outing with a friend
- Host someone for coffee at home
- Join a group activity or class

My safe people (who I can be honest with about how I feel):

1. Name: _____ How to reach: _____
2. Name: _____ How to reach: _____
3. Name: _____ How to reach: _____
4. Name: _____ How to reach: _____

SLEEP HYGIENE WORKSHEET

Depression disrupts sleep (too much OR too little). Good sleep = better mood.

MY SLEEP GOALS:

Bedtime: _____ Wake time: _____ Total hours target: _____

SLEEP HYGIENE CHECKLIST (check what you'll commit to):

- ☐ Same wake time every day (even weekends)
- ☐ No screens 30 min before bed
- ☐ Bedroom is dark, cool, and quiet
- ☐ No caffeine after 2 PM
- ☐ No naps longer than 20 minutes
- ☐ Get sunlight within 30 min of waking
- ☐ Wind-down routine (bath, reading, stretching)
- ☐ Bed is for sleep only (not phone/TV/work)
- ☐ If awake 20 min, get up and do something boring
- ☐ Limit alcohol (disrupts sleep quality)

SLEEP LOG:

Day	Bed Time	Wake Time	Hours	Quality(1-10)	Mood AM
Mon	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____
Tue	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____
Wed	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____
Thu	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____
Fri	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____
Sat	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____
Sun	_____	_____	_____	_____	_____

RUMINATION INTERRUPTION TECHNIQUES

Rumination = replaying negative thoughts over and over without solving anything.
It feels productive but actually deepens depression.

RECOGNIZE: Am I problem-solving or ruminating?

Problem-solving: Leads to a plan of action

Rumination: Goes in circles, focuses on 'why me', no solution

INTERRUPTION TECHNIQUES:

1. THE 5-4-3-2-1 GROUNDING:

5 things I see: _____

4 things I can touch: _____

3 things I hear: _____

2 things I smell: _____

1 thing I taste: _____

2. SCHEDULE RUMINATION TIME: Give yourself 15 min at a set time.

Outside that time, write the thought down and POSTPONE it.

3. CHANGE PHYSICAL STATE: Stand up, splash cold water, hold ice.

4. MENTAL SHIFT: Count backward from 100 by 7s, name countries A-Z.

5. ASK: 'Will this matter in 5 years?' If no, redirect attention.

My go-to interruption technique: _____

VALUES IDENTIFICATION WORKSHEET

Depression disconnects you from what matters. Reconnect with your values.

Rate importance (1-10) and how well you're living this value (1-10):

Value Area	Importance	Living it?	Gap
Family/Relationships	_____	_____	_____
Health/Physical well-being	_____	_____	_____
Career/Work	_____	_____	_____
Friendship/Social	_____	_____	_____
Spirituality/Faith	_____	_____	_____
Learning/Growth	_____	_____	_____
Creativity/Self-expression	_____	_____	_____
Fun/Recreation	_____	_____	_____
Service/Helping others	_____	_____	_____
Independence/Freedom	_____	_____	_____
Honesty/Integrity	_____	_____	_____
Nature/Environment	_____	_____	_____

My TOP 3 values I want to reconnect with:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

One small action I can take THIS WEEK toward my #1 value:

GOAL-SETTING WHEN DEPRESSED

Depression makes everything feel impossible. The key: TINY goals.

RULES FOR DEPRESSION-FRIENDLY GOALS:

1. Make it so small it feels almost too easy
2. Focus on DOING, not FEELING (you can't control feelings)
3. Be specific: what, when, where
4. No 'should' or 'must' - use 'I choose to'
5. Celebrate completion regardless of how it felt

EXAMPLE: Instead of 'Exercise more' --> 'Walk to mailbox Monday at 9am'

MY GOALS FOR THIS WEEK:

Goal 1: _____

When/Where: _____ Done? ☐

Goal 2: _____

When/Where: _____ Done? ☐

Goal 3: _____

When/Where: _____ Done? ☐

Goal 4: _____

When/Where: _____ Done? ☐

Goal 5: _____

When/Where: _____ Done? ☐

WEEKLY MOOD & ACTIVITY LOG - Week 1

Day	Mood(1-10)	Energy(1-10)	Activities Completed	P/M Rating
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Patterns I notice:

Highest mood day & what I did:

Lowest mood day & what was different:

WEEKLY MOOD & ACTIVITY LOG - Week 2

Day	Mood(1-10)	Energy(1-10)	Activities Completed	P/M Rating
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Patterns I notice:

Highest mood day & what I did:

Lowest mood day & what was different:

WEEKLY MOOD & ACTIVITY LOG - Week 3

Day	Mood(1-10)	Energy(1-10)	Activities Completed	P/M Rating
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Patterns I notice:

Highest mood day & what I did:

Lowest mood day & what was different:

WEEKLY MOOD & ACTIVITY LOG - Week 4

Day	Mood(1-10)	Energy(1-10)	Activities Completed	P/M Rating
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Patterns I notice:

Highest mood day & what I did:

Lowest mood day & what was different:

IDENTIFYING MY DEPRESSION CYCLE

Map YOUR specific depression cycle below:

1. My typical depressive THOUGHTS:

2. How these thoughts make me FEEL (emotions + body):

3. What I DO (or stop doing) when I feel this way:

4. How my behaviors make the thoughts/feelings WORSE:

5. WHERE CAN I BREAK THE CYCLE? (circle one):

Change a THOUGHT | Change a BEHAVIOR | Both

6. My specific plan to interrupt the cycle:

RELAPSE WARNING SIGNS

Depression often returns gradually. Knowing YOUR early signs helps you act quickly before a full episode develops.

MY EARLY WARNING SIGNS (check those that apply to you):

- ☐ Sleeping more than usual / difficulty getting out of bed
- ☐ Canceling plans with friends/family
- ☐ Letting dishes/laundry/mail pile up
- ☐ Negative self-talk increasing
- ☐ Loss of interest in things I usually enjoy
- ☐ Increased irritability or tearfulness
- ☐ Difficulty concentrating / brain fog
- ☐ Changes in appetite (eating more or less)
- ☐ Physical symptoms (headaches, body aches)
- ☐ Withdrawing from social media / not responding to messages
- ☐ Skipping self-care routines (showering, brushing teeth)
- ☐ Thoughts of hopelessness returning

My personal early signs not listed above:

When I notice 3+ signs, I will:

MY SUPPORT PLAN

My therapist/counselor:

Phone:

My doctor:

Phone:

Crisis line: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline

People I can call when I'm struggling:

1. Name: _____ **Phone:** _____

2. Name: _____ **Phone:** _____

3. Name: _____ **Phone:** _____

Things that have helped me in past episodes:

My non-negotiable self-care (things I do even on worst days):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Medications (name/dose/time):

I will seek emergency help if:

30-DAY BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION CHALLENGE

Do ONE thing each day. Check off when done. Tiny counts!

- ☐ Day 1: Get out of bed within 10 min of alarm
- ☐ Day 2: Take a 5-minute walk (around block or house)
- ☐ Day 3: Text or call one person
- ☐ Day 4: Cook or prepare one meal (not just snacks)
- ☐ Day 5: Take a full shower and get dressed
- ☐ Day 6: Do one load of laundry (start to finish)
- ☐ Day 7: Go to a store or public place for 10 min
- ☐ Day 8: Write down 3 things you accomplished this week
- ☐ Day 9: Listen to music that used to make you feel good
- ☐ Day 10: Spend 10 min in sunlight/outdoors
- ☐ Day 11: Clean one small area (one counter, one shelf)
- ☐ Day 12: Reach out to someone you've been avoiding
- ☐ Day 13: Do 5 minutes of gentle stretching
- ☐ Day 14: HALFWAY! Rate mood vs Day 1. Celebrate progress.
- ☐ Day 15: Try one new or forgotten activity for 15 min
- ☐ Day 16: Write a brief gratitude list (3 items)
- ☐ Day 17: Go to bed at a planned time tonight
- ☐ Day 18: Help someone with something small
- ☐ Day 19: Eat at a table (not in bed/couch) for one meal
- ☐ Day 20: Spend 15 min on a hobby or creative activity
- ☐ Day 21: Attend a social event (even online counts)
- ☐ Day 22: Do one task you've been putting off
- ☐ Day 23: Practice the 5-4-3-2-1 grounding exercise
- ☐ Day 24: Move your body for 15 minutes (any movement)
- ☐ Day 25: Declutter one small space
- ☐ Day 26: Do something kind for yourself
- ☐ Day 27: Plan one enjoyable activity for next week
- ☐ Day 28: Review your values - do one value-based action
- ☐ Day 29: Write what has changed since Day 1
- ☐ Day 30: Create your ongoing self-care plan

THOUGHT CHALLENGE WORKSHEET

Situation #1:

Automatic thought:

Emotion + intensity (0-100%):

Evidence for:

Evidence against:

Balanced thought:

Emotion now (0-100%):

Situation #2:

Automatic thought:

Emotion + intensity (0-100%):

Evidence for:

Evidence against:

Balanced thought:

Emotion now (0-100%):

BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION SCHEDULE - Week 2

Plan activities that mix Pleasure (P) and Mastery (M).

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning							
Midday							
Afternoon							
Evening							

Activities that gave me the most pleasure this week:

Activities that gave me the most mastery this week:

CHALLENGING SELF-CRITICAL THOUGHTS

Depression amplifies your inner critic. Common self-critical thoughts:

'I'm not good enough' 'I always mess things up' 'I'm lazy'

THE COMPASSIONATE RESPONSE TECHNIQUE:

My self-critical thought:

What a harsh critic would say (write it out):

What a compassionate friend would say instead:

Evidence that I am NOT what my critic says:

1.

2.

3.

What I would tell my best friend if they said this about themselves:

My compassionate response to myself:

BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION SCHEDULE - Week 3

Increase difficulty slightly. Add one new activity per day.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning							
Midday							
Afternoon							
Evening							

New activities I tried this week:

Mood improvement noticed (1-10): _____

BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION SCHEDULE - Week 4

Maintain momentum. Focus on sustainability.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning							
Midday							
Afternoon							
Evening							

Activities I want to keep doing permanently:

MOVING FORWARD: MY ONGOING PLAN

CBT skills that work best for me:

My daily non-negotiables (things I do every day):

My weekly non-negotiables:

My warning signs to watch for:

When I notice warning signs, I will:

My reason for continuing to fight depression:

What I want my life to look like in 6 months:
